

GEARING UP FOR A SHOT AT OLYMPIC GLORY

Guided by her coach and her own resilience, Manu Bhaker's journey back to form culminates in a **remarkable return to the top of her game**, as she sets sights on Paris Olympics with renewed determination.

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It's easy to understand why Indian shooters in the women's 25m pistol event were a bundle of nerves a day before the start of the third Olympic trials at the MP Shooting Academy in Bhopal last month. With a spot in the national Olympic team on the line, there was much at stake. Therefore, while some were meditating in preparation for the event, others were revising their dry firing techniques.

But Manu Bhaker wasn't doing any of that. **In her hotel room in Bhopal, she pulled out a violin (a birthday gift from her brother), scrunched her face in concentration, and started playing the Indian national anthem, practising to get the notes just right.**

As far as musical instruments go, the violin — which, unlike the guitar, has no guides on its bridge for finger placement — is considered one of the hardest to learn. But, Manu took her first music class just four months before the Olympics. She makes a valiant attempt to play her first song. It's fair to say she loves it, although not everyone is as enthused.

"Baaki sab match ki taiyari kar rahe hain aur Manu violin baja rahi thi (Everyone else is preparing for the match, and Manu is playing the violin)," her coach Jaspal Rana later said in mock exasperation.

Call it bravado or supreme self-confidence, but the fact is Manu is at the top of her game. She gets her rendition of the song she is practising as well as her shooting, nearly perfect. At the Olympic selection trials, she came out on top in both the 10m pistol and 25m pistol events, averaging 579.53 in the former and 586.47 in the latter.

She also improved on the finals world record twice in the 25m pistol event.

Still only 22, Manu will be India's youngest two-time Olympian. She will likely take part in three separate events in Paris, more than any other Indian competitor. While she took part in three events in Tokyo as well, this version of Manu Bhaker is older, wiser, and likely better prepared. But it's the kind of progress that hasn't happened seamlessly.

A little less than a year ago, Manu was done with the sport. It wasn't as if she was shooting badly. She was still a part of the Indian team and posted strong scores. But that was